CHAPTER 52

‘I WANT JIMMY BACK’

5–9 February 2021

INDIA vs ENGLAND, 1st Test, *MA Chidambaram Stadium*, *Chennai*

England 578 and 178; India 337 and 192

England won by 227 runs

England 1st innings**: J Root 218**; India 2nd innings: **J Anderson 11–4–17–3**

As the world gets back to normal, mine continues the same as always – focusing on what and who is next. Living in stubborn denial of age, pushing my body further, still running in, up hills and out of problems and into battle for England. I’ve bowled one of my favourite overs in my career, dismissing both Shubman Gill and Ajinkya Rahane in Chennai. They are both excellent at home – beautiful technicians and young masters of their conditions – but the ball reverse-swings almost cartoonishly in India and when it does, there is nothing more fun for me in the world. The ball swings back in late and aggressively to both of them, leaving them frozen in perfect orthodox defensive shots, their stumps out of the ground. It’s as good a feeling as there is.

Not long after, Ashley Giles, now a coach at Lancashire, gets in touch and tells me that they’d like to name an end at Old Trafford after me. There is the Brian Statham End, but the other end remains nameless at the ground. With the James Anderson End, I would become maybe the only living cricketer to still be bowling at an end named after them. It feels like a huge deal but, to look back on it, to dwell on it, presents some kind of danger to me. To reflect and bathe in it would maybe mean I am done, when I am not. This sort of danger – between being mythologised yet still wanting to